

Evergreen Shrubs — Agent-Grade Care Narrative

(Priority Tagged)

Purpose: agent-readable horticultural narrative for generating care schedules and cautions. Priority tags: P1=survival-critical, P2=establishment success, P3=optimization, P4=advanced/reference. P1 statements are conservative and exception-aware.

A. Site & Light Requirements (P1)

- Acceptable range: full sun to partial shade; match plant tag for best performance.
- Avoid deep shade for sun-preferring evergreens (thin growth, stress).
- Avoid extreme reflected afternoon heat on broadleaf evergreens (leaf scorch risk).

B. Temperature & Climate Constraints (P1)

- Planting allowed only when soil is workable (not frozen, not waterlogged).
- Minimum soil temperature guideline for planting: ~40°F (4°C) and rising.
- Heat-stress risk increases sharply in hot, dry weather; treat prolonged >90°F (32°C) as high-risk during establishment.
- Hard-freeze risk: <28°F (-2°C) shortly after planting increases dehydration/winter burn risk; protect roots and foliage.

C. Seasonal Timing / Planting Window (P1)

- Best for most evergreens: autumn or spring (roots establish with less heat stress).
- Container-grown shrubs can be planted outside ideal windows but require substantially more aftercare.
- Avoid planting in hot/dry periods; avoid peak winter when soil is frozen or saturated.
- Winter exception: in mild climates, winter planting is acceptable if soil is workable and irrigation is available during dry spells.

D. Watering & Moisture Profile (Day 0–30) (P1)

- Water in thoroughly at planting (Day 0).
- Days 1–14: check soil moisture daily; water deeply when the top few inches are dry and the root ball is not moist.
- Rule of thumb schedule (adjust to weather/soil): Weeks 1–2: water daily; Weeks 3–12: every 2–3 days; then weekly until established.
- Water at the base; avoid frequent light sprinkling (encourages shallow roots).
- Avoid saturation: if soil is soggy or standing water persists, pause watering and address drainage.

E. Soil Requirements (P2)

- Drainage is critical: most evergreens fail in chronically wet soils (root rot).
- Preferred pH varies by species; default safe range for many landscape evergreens is ~6.0–7.0 unless known acid-loving.
- Improve drainage/structure with organic matter in the planting area; avoid creating a 'pot in a hole' in heavy clay.

F. Planting & Installation Rules (P1)

- Set root flare at or slightly above finished grade; never bury the trunk/stem base.
- Loosen circling roots; ensure good soil-root contact (no air pockets).
- Mulch 2–3 inches over the root zone; keep mulch 2–3 inches away from stems/trunks.
- Stake only if necessary (wind exposure/top-heavy); remove supports after establishment.

G. Fertilization Guidance (P1)

- Avoid quick-release fertilizer at planting; it can inhibit root growth and increase stress.
- Do not fertilize drought-stressed shrubs; fertilize only after adequate rooting, or if a soil test indicates need.
- Safe default: defer fertilization until after establishment (often after the first flush/season), then use slow-release at label rates.

H. Pest & Disease Risk (Early Window) (P2)

- Hot/dry stress increases spider mite risk on many evergreens; inspect foliage weekly in heat.
- Overwatering + poor drainage increases root-rot risk; treat persistent wilting with wet soil as a drainage issue, not a watering deficit.
- Avoid wetting foliage late in the day in humid periods (disease pressure).

I. Weed Competition Sensitivity (P2)

- Keep a weed-free mulched ring around the root zone to reduce competition for moisture.
- Avoid herbicide contact with green stems and avoid pre-emergents unless label-safe for the plant and timing.

J. Weather Exception Handling (P1)

- Heat wave (multiple days of high temps/wind): increase watering frequency; add temporary shade for broadleaf evergreens.
- Heavy rain: pause irrigation; confirm water drains within 24 hours.
- Frost/hard freeze soon after planting: water before freeze if soil is dry and above freezing; protect with burlap/frost cloth; refresh mulch.
- Winter dry spell (evergreen): water on a mild day if soil is not frozen and temperatures are above ~40°F.

K. Growth & Establishment Signals (P2)

- Normal: mild leaf drop, temporary dullness, slight wilt during first days that recovers after watering.
- Concerning: persistent wilting despite moist soil, progressive browning/scorch, dieback at tips.
- Recovery indicator: foliage firms up and new root/terminal growth appears in season.

L. Safety & Customer Guardrails (P1)

- Never bury the root flare.
- Do not 'sip water' daily—water deeply, then re-water based on moisture check.
- Avoid fertilizing at planting or during drought/heat stress.

M. Location-Based Modifiers (P2)

- Hot urban/reflective sites: treat as higher heat zone; increase shade and watering vigilance.
- Cold windy exposure: windbreak/burlap for first winter; prioritize fall planting only if adequate time before hard freezes.
- High rainfall regions: prioritize raised planting and drainage improvements.

N. Lifecycle Transition (Post 30 Days) (P4)

- After stabilization: shift from establishment schedule to weather-based deep watering; avoid frequent shallow irrigation.
- Pruning is species-dependent; restrict to dead/damaged wood until established.